NextGen Nurses

PTE ACADEMIC · REVIEW GUIDE

Tips and strategies for every PTE task.

A practical review of all 22 PTE Academic question types, written for nurses working towards registration in Australia. Updated for the current test format, including Respond to a Situation and Summarize Group Discussion.

Speaking | Writing | Reading | Listening | Study plan | Checklists

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GOLDEN RULES

Speak fluently and naturally. Never stay silent for more than three seconds. Check spelling and grammar in every written answer. Practise every task type under timed conditions, and review every mistake.

How to use this guide

- **Read sections 1 to 3 first.** They explain how the test works and which habits lose marks, whatever your level.
- **Then work task by task.** Each task card gives the timing, what is being tested, a step-by-step method and the most common mistakes.
- **Practise as you read.** A tip only becomes a skill once you have used it under time pressure. The NextGen Nurses PTE Practice App lets you try every task with real timings.
- **Use the checklists in section 10** in the last week before your test.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Pearson updates PTE Academic from time to time, and Ahpra sets the scores nurses need. The details in this guide were checked in November 2026. Always confirm the current format on Pearson's website and the current minimum scores on Ahpra's *Accepted English language tests* page before you book.

A note for nurses

Many internationally qualified nurses find that their clinical English is strong but their PTE scores do not show it. PTE does not test nursing knowledge. It tests how quickly and accurately you can process academic English on a computer, often on topics far from health care. The good news is that most lost marks come from technique, not from your level of English, and technique can be trained in a few weeks.

Speaking is usually the hardest target for nurses, because the Board requires a high Speaking score. That is why this guide gives the speaking tasks the most space.

SECTION 1

The test at a glance

PTE Academic is taken on a computer at a test centre with a headset and microphone. It lasts about two hours and has three parts. There is no break between tasks, and you cannot go back to a task once you have moved on.

Task	Items*	Timing
Part 1 · Speaking and Writing (about 76 to 84 minutes)		
Personal Introduction	1	25 s to prepare, 30 s to speak. Not scored, but sent to institutions.
Read Aloud	6–7	30–40 s to prepare; text up to 60 words
Repeat Sentence	10–12	Sentence of 3–9 s, heard once; 15 s to answer
Describe Image	5–6	25 s to prepare, 40 s to speak
Re-tell Lecture	2–3	Lecture up to 90 s; 10 s to prepare, 40 s to speak
Answer Short Question	5–6	Question of 3–9 s; 10 s to answer
Summarize Group Discussion NEW 2025	2–3	Discussion up to 3 min; 10 s to prepare, 2 min to speak
Respond to a Situation NEW 2025	2–3	Situation on screen and audio; 10 s to prepare, 40 s to speak
Summarize Written Text	2	10 min each; one sentence of 5–75 words
Write Essay	1	20 min; 200–300 words
Part 2 · Reading (about 23 to 30 minutes, one shared clock)		
Reading & Writing: Fill in the Blanks	5–6	Drop-down list for each blank
Multiple Choice, Multiple Answers	2–3	Wrong choices lose marks
Re-order Paragraphs	2–3	Drag sentences into order
Reading: Fill in the Blanks	4–5	Drag words from a box
Multiple Choice, Single Answer	2–3	One correct option
Part 3 · Listening (about 31 to 39 minutes; recordings play once)		
Summarize Spoken Text	1–2	Recording 60–90 s; 10 min; 50–70 words
Multiple Choice, Multiple Answers	2–3	Wrong choices lose marks
Fill in the Blanks	2–3	Type the missing words as you listen
Highlight Correct Summary	2–3	Choose the best of four summaries
Multiple Choice, Single Answer	2–3	One correct option
Select Missing Word	1–2	The ending is replaced by a beep
Highlight Incorrect Words	2–3	Wrong clicks lose marks
Write from Dictation	3–4	Sentence of 3–5 s; type it exactly

* Item numbers vary from test to test. Figures are based on Pearson's published ranges for the current format.

The scores nurses need

For tests taken on or after 23 April 2026, the Nursing and Midwifery Board of Australia accepts PTE Academic with at least these scores:

63	58	59	60	76
OVERALL	LISTENING	READING	WRITING	SPEAKING

WHICH TASKS LIFT YOUR SPEAKING SCORE

Speaking is fed by Read Aloud, Repeat Sentence, Describe Image, Re-tell Lecture, Respond to a Situation and Summarize Group Discussion. Repeat Sentence and Read Aloud have the most items, so daily practice of these two is the most reliable way to raise a Speaking score.

Ahpra also has rules about combining results from more than one sitting and about tests taken before 23 April 2026. Check the current standard on the Ahpra website before you book, because these settings can change.

SECTION 2

How PTE is scored

Understanding the scoring is the fastest way to stop wasting marks. Four ideas matter most.

1. Most tasks score more than one skill

PTE is an integrated test. Many tasks feed two of the four skill scores at once. Repeat Sentence, for example, counts for both Listening and Speaking, and Write from Dictation counts for both Listening and Writing. A weak skill can therefore pull down another, and a task you practise every day can lift two scores together.

Your four skill scores and your overall score are each reported on a scale from 10 to 90.

2. Speaking is marked on content, fluency and pronunciation

CONTENT

Did you say the right things? For Read Aloud and Repeat Sentence this means the correct words in the correct order. For longer tasks it means covering the main points.

ORAL FLUENCY AND PRONUNCIATION

Did you speak smoothly, at a natural pace, with clear sounds and natural stress? These are scored by computer, so a steady, even delivery matters more than an impressive accent.

Fluency carries a great deal of weight. A response with a few small content gaps but smooth, confident delivery usually scores better than a perfect answer full of pauses, restarts and corrections.

3. Content on seven tasks is now checked by people as well as computers

Since the 2025 update, human reviewers help score the **content** of Describe Image, Re-tell Lecture, Respond to a Situation, Summarize Group Discussion, Summarize Written Text, Write Essay and Summarize Spoken Text. Pronunciation and fluency are still scored by computer only.

TEMPLATES: USE A STRUCTURE, NOT A SCRIPT

Long memorised templates, such as a fixed 30-word opening for every Describe Image or a pre-written essay introduction full of words like *indubitably* and *irrefutably*, are now risky. Generic answers that could fit any question are easier to spot and score poorly for content. Learn a **flexible structure** and a bank of short phrases, then fill it with what is actually in front of you.

4. Know which tasks punish guessing

Scoring type	Tasks	What to do
Negative marking: +1 for each correct choice, −1 for each wrong one (never below zero)	Reading and Listening Multiple Choice, Multiple Answers; Highlight Incorrect Words	Choose only what you are sure of. One confident answer is safer than three guesses.
Right or wrong: no penalty for a wrong answer	Both Multiple Choice, Single Answer; Highlight Correct Summary; Select Missing Word	Never leave these blank. Always make your best guess.
Partial credit: marks for each correct part	Fill in the Blanks (all three types); Re-order Paragraphs (scored on correct neighbouring pairs); Write from Dictation (each correct word)	Fill every blank and type every word you caught. Something always beats nothing.
Form check: wrong form can mean zero for the whole item	Summarize Written Text, Write Essay, Summarize Spoken Text	Respect the word limits and, for Summarize Written Text, the one-sentence rule.

SECTION 3

Test-day rules that cost marks

These habits apply across the whole test. Candidates who know their English well still lose points by breaking them.

THE THREE-SECOND RULE

In speaking tasks, the microphone closes if you are silent for about three seconds. Start speaking within one or two seconds of the beep, and never stop to think mid-answer. If you lose your place, keep talking about what you can see or remember.

WAIT FOR "COMPLETED"

After a speaking task, click Next only once the recording box shows that it has finished. Clicking too early can cut off your answer.

NO GOING BACK

Once you click Next, the task is closed. Check your answer before you move on, then put it out of your mind. Dwelling on a weak answer damages the next one.

WATCH THE SHARED CLOCK

Reading, and most of Listening, use one clock for the whole part. Unanswered items at the end score zero, so keep moving. A quick best guess is better than running out of time.

Speaking at a test centre

- **Expect noise.** Other candidates speak nearby, often at the same time as you. Practise with a radio on in the background so it does not throw you.
- **Position the microphone** two finger-widths from the side of your mouth, not directly in front, so your breathing is not recorded.
- **Speak at your normal volume.** Shouting distorts the recording and whispering is hard to score. Speak as you would to a colleague across a nurses' station.
- **Use your natural accent.** Do not imitate an Australian, British or American accent. Clear sounds, word stress and pausing at punctuation matter; the accent itself does not.

Writing and typing

- **Spelling counts everywhere you type.** Choose one spelling system, Australian, British or American, and keep to it throughout.
- **Never type in capitals** and do not use bullet points in written answers.
- **Know the tools.** The screen has Cut, Copy and Paste buttons and a live word count. Keyboard shortcuts may not work, so practise with the buttons.
- **Build typing speed.** Ten minutes of typing practice a day helps dictation and summaries.

Your notes

You receive an erasable notepad and pen; you cannot bring your own paper. Ask for a new pad if yours fills up. Practise symbols and abbreviations (page 20) so your notes keep up with a lecture.

THE DAY BEFORE

Do one short, easy practice session, then stop. Sleep, food and a calm start matter more than one more mock test. Arrive early with your identification, and use the bathroom before you start, because there is no scheduled break in the speaking part.

SECTION 4

Speaking

Seven scored tasks, all in Part 1. For nurses this is usually the decisive section, because the Board requires 76 in Speaking. Fluency and pronunciation run through every task, so start with the general principles below.

FIVE SPEAKING PRINCIPLES

1. **Fluency first.** Keep a steady, even pace. Do not rush and do not drag.
2. **Never correct yourself.** Going back over a word costs more fluency than the mistake costs content.
3. **Pause in natural places**: at commas, full stops and between ideas, never in the middle of a phrase.
4. **Avoid fillers** such as *umm*, *ahh* and *you know*. A short silent pause is better.
5. **Finish your last sentence** before the time runs out, rather than being cut off mid-sentence.

Personal Introduction

25 s prepare · 30 s speak · not scored

This is not scored, but the recording is sent to institutions with your score report, so treat it as a short professional introduction. It also warms up your voice and lets you check the microphone volume.

Say your name, where you are from, your profession and why you are taking the test. For example: *"My name is … I am a registered nurse with six years' experience in surgical and emergency nursing. I am taking this test because I am applying for registration in Australia, where I hope to work in critical care."*

Read Aloud

30–40 s prepare · text up to 60 words

What is tested

Reading a short academic text aloud with every word in place, smooth delivery and clear pronunciation.

Method

1. **Read the whole text silently** during the preparation time, mouthing the words.
2. **Find the difficult words**, such as long names and numbers, and decide how you will say them. Break long words into syllables in your head.
3. **Mark the pauses** mentally at commas and full stops, and notice which words carry the meaning.
4. **Start within a second** of the beep and read at one steady pace to the end.

Common mistakes

- Racing to finish early, which blurs word endings such as *-ed* and *-s*.
- Stopping to restart a sentence after a slip. Keep going; one wrong word is a small loss.
- Reading in a flat, robotic voice. Let your voice rise and fall naturally, with stress on the key words.

Repeat Sentence

Sentence 3–9 s · heard once · 15 s to answer

What is tested

Holding a spoken sentence in short-term memory and repeating it exactly. It feeds both Listening and Speaking, and there are many items, so it is one of the most valuable tasks to practise daily.

Method

1. **Listen for meaning, not single words.** Picture the situation: a library, a lecture, a hospital. A meaning is much easier to hold than a string of sounds.
2. **Hear it in chunks.** Most sentences break into three or four phrases, for example *"The library / will be closed / on Monday / for the public holiday."*
3. **Start speaking straight away.** There is no tone before recording begins, so begin as soon as the recording opens.
4. **Copy the speaker's rhythm** and intonation.

If you lose part of the sentence

Say the parts you remember, in order, fluently. Half a sentence spoken smoothly still earns content, fluency and pronunciation marks. Silence earns nothing.

Describe Image

25 s prepare · 40 s speak

What is tested

Describing a chart, graph, table, map, process or picture clearly and fluently. You will not have time to say everything, and you are not expected to.

Use the preparation time in this order

1. **Title**: what is the image about?
2. **Type and units**: bar chart, line graph, pie chart or table? Percentages, dollars, millions or years?
3. **Highest and lowest**: the biggest and smallest values, or the start and end of a trend.
4. **One comparison or trend**, and a one-line conclusion.

A flexible five-part structure

Part	What to say	Example
1. Overview	Image type, topic and units	*This bar chart compares average hours of sleep across five occupations.*
2. Highest	The largest value, with the figure	*Teachers sleep the most, at around 7.2 hours.*
3. Lowest	The smallest value	*Drivers sleep the least, at just under six hours.*
4. Comparison or trend	One relationship between items	*Nurses are also below average, at about six hours.*
5. Conclusion	The main message in one sentence	*Overall, people in shift work appear to sleep less than others.*

This takes about 30 to 35 seconds when spoken at a natural pace. If you have time left, add one more detail. If time is short, skip to the conclusion.

Short openers to have ready (then describe what is actually shown): *This bar chart shows… · The line graph illustrates… · The table compares… · The diagram shows how… · This picture shows…*

Approximate the numbers

You do not need exact figures. Words such as *about*, *around*, *just over*, *just under*, *nearly* and *roughly* let you keep talking instead of squinting at the axis.

Adapt to the image type

Bar chart: highest, lowest, then one comparison between two bars.

Line graph: starting point, the overall direction, any peak or fall, and the end point.

Pie chart: the largest and smallest shares, and what the biggest two slices add up to.

Table: pick one row or column to describe; do not read out every cell.

Map or plan: use position words such as *in the north-east*, *next to*, *opposite*, *in the centre*.

Process or cycle: name the first and last stages, and link the middle with *first*, *then*, *after that*, *finally*.

For a **photograph** or picture, describe what is in the foreground and background, who or what is shown, what is happening, and what the picture suggests.

The language for trends is on page 22.

Re-tell Lecture

Lecture up to 90 s · 10 s prepare · 40 s speak

What is tested

Understanding a short academic talk and re-telling its main points in your own words, fluently.

Note-taking

- **Write key words only**: nouns, numbers and names, never full sentences. Use symbols and abbreviations (page 21).
- **Divide your page** into topic, two or three main points, and conclusion.
- **Listen to the end.** Speakers often add or change a point in the final sentences.
- If an image appears with the lecture, use it for clues about the topic.

Structure your answer

Topic: *The lecture was about ... / The speaker discussed ...*
Point 1: *She explained that ... / According to the speaker, ...*
Point 2: *He also pointed out that ... / In addition, ...*
Point 3: *Another point was that ... / For example, ...*
Conclusion: *In conclusion, the speaker suggested that ... / Overall, the main message was that ...*

- **Follow the speaker's order**; it is the most natural way to organise your notes.
- **Mention only what the speaker said**, not your own opinions or knowledge.
- Simplify names: *"a researcher"* or *"the professor"* is fine if you did not catch the name.

Answer Short Question

Question 3–9 s · 10 s to answer

Answer with one word or a short phrase. *"A thermometer"* is enough; a full sentence earns nothing extra and wastes time. Include *a*, *an* or *the* where it sounds natural. If you are unsure, give your best guess immediately, using words from the question if nothing else comes to mind, because silence scores zero. Some questions show an image; look at it while you listen.

These questions test everyday and general vocabulary, not specialist knowledge. Build word lists by topic, and drill 10 to 15 questions a day out loud with the NextGen Nurses Answer Short Questions Review in your PTE bundle:

Topic	Examples of words to know
Time and numbers	decade, century, millennium, fortnight, quarter, dozen, annual, half
The body and health	wrist, ankle, skull, lungs, kidneys, pulse, stethoscope, thermometer, X-ray, surgeon, pharmacist, vaccine
Science and nature	astronomer, telescope, microscope, oxygen, evaporation, eclipse, continent, hemisphere, mammal
Study and work	bibliography, thesis, semester, lecturer, resume, receipt, salary, deadline, interview
Places and people	pharmacy, gallery, library, architect, plumber, referee, pilot, dentist, landlord
Opposites and categories	expand / contract, import / export, maximum / minimum, urban / rural, ancient / modern

Respond to a Situation NEW 2025

10 s prepare · 40 s speak

What is tested

Responding naturally and appropriately to an everyday or workplace situation, as if the person were in front of you. The situation appears on screen and is also read aloud.

Method

1. **Identify who you are speaking to**: a manager, tutor, patient, neighbour or friend. This decides how formal you should be.
2. **Identify what you need to achieve**: apologise, ask for something, explain, persuade, decline or reassure.
3. **Speak to the person directly**, using *you*, not *"I would tell him that..."*.

Four-step response

1. **Greet and open**: *"Hi Sam, have you got a minute?"* / *"Excuse me, Dr Lee."*
2. **State the issue**: *"I wanted to let you know that..."* / *"I'm really sorry, but..."*
3. **Give a reason or a solution**: *"The reason is..."* / *"What I can do is..."* / *"Would it be possible to...?"*
4. **Close politely**: *"Thanks so much for understanding."* / *"I'll let you know by tomorrow."*

Tone

Match your tone to the relationship. With a lecturer or manager, use polite forms such as *could you*, *would it be possible* and *I was wondering if*. With a friend or flatmate you can be warmer and more relaxed. With a patient or customer, acknowledge their feelings first, then explain what you will do.

A NURSING ADVANTAGE

You already use this skill at work every day: explaining a delay to a family, raising a concern with a doctor, reassuring an anxious patient. Draw on the calm, structured way you would handle those conversations on the ward.

Summarize Group Discussion NEW 2025

Discussion up to 3 min · 10 s prepare · 2 min speak

What is tested

Following a conversation between three people and summarising who said what, and how the discussion ended. It feeds both Listening and Speaking.

Note-taking

Draw three columns on your notepad, one per speaker. For each person, note their **opinion** and their **reason**. At the bottom, note the **outcome**: did they agree, compromise or decide to do something?

Structure

"The discussion was about..."
"The first speaker argued that... because..."
"The second speaker disagreed, pointing out that..."
"The third speaker suggested..."
"In the end, they agreed to... / They decided that..."

Tips

- **Use reporting verbs** to show each person's attitude: *argued, suggested, pointed out, disagreed, agreed, proposed, was concerned that, concluded.*
- **Speak for at least a minute and a half** of your two minutes. Keep a steady pace; you do not need to fill every second.
- **Always include the outcome.** It is the part most candidates forget.

SECTION 5

Writing

Two written tasks come at the end of Part 1, and two more writing-heavy tasks appear in Listening. Grammar, spelling and the word limits are marked strictly, so the last two minutes of every writing task are for checking.

Summarize Written Text

10 min · passage up to 300 words · ONE sentence, 5–75 words

The form rules

Write **one sentence only**: a capital letter at the start, a single full stop at the end, and between 5 and 75 words. Break these rules and the whole response can score zero. There are no extra marks for length; a clear sentence of **25 to 45 words** is the safest target.

Method (about 3 minutes reading, 5 writing, 2 checking)

1. **Find the main idea.** It is often in the first or last sentence of the passage, or the idea that keeps returning.
2. **Pick two or three supporting points**, usually one from each paragraph. Leave out examples, figures and names.
3. **Note each paragraph in a few words**, then join the notes into one sentence with connectors such as *and, while, although, which*. You may reuse key words from the text, but change the surrounding words where you can.
4. **Write in the third person**: avoid *I* and *we*. Capitalise names and proper nouns.
5. **Check** spelling, plurals, verb agreement, the full stop and the word count.

Sentence patterns that join ideas

Although [contrast point], [main idea], *which* [result or extra point].
[Main idea] *because* [reason], *and* [second point].
[Main idea]*; however,* [problem or limitation], *so* [conclusion].
While [point A], [point B], *meaning that* [result].

EXAMPLE

Although hospitals once restricted visiting hours, research showing that family presence reduces patient anxiety without increasing infection has led many to allow relatives at any time, which works best when clear expectations are set. (36 words, one sentence)

A semicolon followed by *however* is a useful way to add a contrast while keeping one sentence. Avoid listing many short clauses joined by *and … and … and*.

Write Essay

20 min · 200–300 words

What is tested

Answering the question with a clear position, organised paragraphs and supporting ideas, in correct, varied English. The content is now checked by human reviewers as well, so the essay must answer **this** question, not a general topic.

Time plan

2–3 minutes	Read the question twice. Decide the essay type and your position. Note two main ideas with one example each.
14–15 minutes	Write four paragraphs, about 250 words in total.
2–3 minutes	Check spelling, plurals, verb endings, articles and the word count.

Identify the essay type first

If the question asks…	Plan
To what extent do you agree? / **Do you agree or disagree?**	State your position in the introduction. Body 1: your strongest reason with an example. Body 2: a second reason, or the opposing view and why you still disagree with it. Conclusion: restate your position.
Discuss both views and give your opinion.	Body 1: the first view and its reasons. Body 2: the second view and its reasons. Give your own opinion clearly in the introduction and conclusion.
Advantages and disadvantages / **Do the advantages outweigh…?**	Body 1: advantages. Body 2: disadvantages. If asked whether one outweighs the other, say which, and why, in the introduction and conclusion.
Causes and solutions / **Problems and solutions**	Body 1: two causes or problems. Body 2: a matching solution for each. Conclusion: summarise.
Two-part question (for example, "Why is this happening, and is it positive?")	Answer each part in its own body paragraph, in the order asked.

Paragraph plan

INTRODUCTION (40–50 WORDS)

One sentence that restates the topic in your own words. One sentence that gives your position or what the essay will cover.

BODY PARAGRAPHS (80–90 WORDS EACH)

Topic sentence with one main idea. Explanation: why or how. A specific example. A link back to the question.

CONCLUSION (30–40 WORDS)

Summarise your two main ideas and restate your position. Do not add new ideas.

Common mistakes

- Going under 200 or over 300 words. Watch the live count.
- Copying long parts of the question. Restate it in your own words.
- A memorised introduction that does not mention the actual topic.
- Very long sentences that lose control of grammar. Mix short and medium sentences.
- Forgetting to give an opinion when the question asks for one.

Write Essay: a model plan

Question: *Some people believe that governments should spend more on preventing illness than on treating it. To what extent do you agree or disagree?*

Type: agree or disagree. **Position:** largely agree, with a limit.

- **Introduction:** health budgets are under pressure; I largely agree that prevention deserves more funding, although treatment cannot be neglected.
- **Body 1:** prevention is cheaper and reduces suffering. Example: vaccination and screening programs that avoid costly hospital admissions later.
- **Body 2:** however, people who are already ill still need hospitals, and the results of prevention take years to appear, so treatment funding must be protected.
- **Conclusion:** shift the balance towards prevention while maintaining essential treatment services.

Useful language for essays

Purpose	Phrases
Introducing the topic	It is often argued that... · In recent years, ... has become a widely discussed issue. · Many people believe that...
Giving your position	I largely agree that... · In my view, ... · This essay will argue that... · I partly agree, because...
Adding a point	Firstly, ... · In addition, ... · Furthermore, ... · Another important factor is...
Giving an example	For example, ... · For instance, ... · A clear example of this is... · This can be seen in...
Showing contrast	However, ... · On the other hand, ... · Although..., ... · Despite this, ...
Showing result	As a result, ... · Therefore, ... · This means that... · Consequently, ...
Concluding	In conclusion, ... · Overall, ... · To sum up, ... · For these reasons, I believe that...

Practice topics by theme

Essay topics cover general academic themes. Practise at least two from each group, writing to time.

Education
Should university education be free for everyone? Are written exams the best way to assess students? Should children learn a second language from primary school?

Technology and media
Has social media made people more or less connected? Do the benefits of working from home outweigh the drawbacks? Is technology making people less active?

Health
Should governments tax unhealthy food? Who is responsible for an individual's health, the person or the government? Should advertising of unhealthy food to children be banned?

Environment
Who should be responsible for reducing packaging waste, consumers or producers? Should cities ban cars from their centres? What can individuals do about climate change?

Work and society
Why do people work long hours, and what are the effects? Should older people be encouraged to keep working? Is it better to work for a large company or a small one?

Travel and culture
Does tourism do more good than harm to local communities? Should young people work or travel before university? Is studying abroad necessary for a good education?

Summarize Spoken Text

Listening · recording 60–90 s · 10 min · 50–70 words

This task sits in the Listening part but is a writing task, so it is covered here. It feeds both Listening and Writing.

Method

1. **Take notes throughout** in three groups: topic, three or four main points, conclusion.
2. **Write two or three full sentences**, not one long one. Begin with the topic, then the main points in the order you heard them.
3. **Stay between 50 and 70 words.** Outside that range you lose marks for form.
4. **Check spelling and grammar** in the last two minutes.

Structure

The speaker discussed [topic]. He explained that [point 1] and [point 2]. She also noted that [point 3]. Overall, [main message or conclusion].

EXAMPLE (58 WORDS)

The speaker explained the placebo effect, in which patients feel better after a treatment with no active ingredient. This happens because expecting relief causes the brain to release its own pain-relieving chemicals. The effect is strongest for symptoms such as pain and nausea, and it increases when the clinician is warm and confident, showing that communication is part of treatment.

Spelling and grammar checklist for every written task

- ☐ Subject and verb agree: *the research **shows**, studies **show***
- ☐ Plurals have *-s*: *many patient**s***
- ☐ Past tense verbs end in *-ed* where needed
- ☐ Articles are in place: *a*, *an*, *the*
- ☐ Every sentence starts with a capital letter
- ☐ One spelling system used throughout
- ☐ No contractions in essays: *do not*, not *don't*
- ☐ Commonly misspelt words checked: *environment, government, necessary, receive, separate, accommodation, which, their*
- ☐ Word count inside the limit
- ☐ No capitals for whole words and no bullet points

SECTION 6

Reading

Five tasks share one clock of about half an hour. Time pressure is the main difficulty, so budget your minutes and do not get stuck on one item.

TIME BUDGET FOR READING

Reading & Writing Fill in the Blanks: about 2 minutes each · Re-order Paragraphs: 2 to 3 minutes each · Reading Fill in the Blanks: about 1.5 minutes each · Multiple Choice: about 1.5 to 2 minutes each. Check the clock after every two or three items.

Reading skills that help in every task

- **Skim first.** Read quickly for the general topic before looking at details. The first sentence of a paragraph usually gives its main idea.
- **Scan for key words.** When you need a detail, run your eyes over the text for the key word or a synonym, then read closely around it.
- **Ignore difficult words** unless the question depends on them. Use the words around them to guess the meaning.
- **Notice signal words**: *however* and *although* show contrast; *therefore* and *as a result* show consequence; *for example* introduces support.

Reading & Writing: Fill in the Blanks

Drop-down list of four options per blank

1. **Read the whole text quickly** first, ignoring the blanks, to understand the topic.
2. **At each blank, decide the word type** before opening the list: noun, verb, adjective, adverb or linking word? Singular or plural? Which tense?
3. **Check the words on both sides.** Many answers are collocations, words that normally go together, such as *pose a threat*, *carry out research*, *play a role*, *known as*, *rely on*.
4. **Check meaning last.** Does the word fit the logic of the sentence: contrast, result or addition?
5. **Read the finished text** once to make sure it makes sense.

Distractors are often a different form of the right word: *recognise, recognising, recognition, recognisable*. Grammar alone often gives you the answer.

Reading: Fill in the Blanks

Drag words from a box · more words than blanks

- Fill the blanks you are sure of first. This reduces the choices for the harder ones.
- The box contains extra words, often similar in meaning or form, so check grammar as well as meaning.
- Fill every blank, even with a guess. There is no penalty for a wrong word.

Re-order Paragraphs

Four or five sentences · marked on correct neighbouring pairs

Find the first sentence

The opening sentence usually introduces the topic and can stand alone. It rarely starts with a pronoun (*he, she, it, they, this, these*), a linking word (*however, therefore, also, as a result*) or *the* followed by something not yet mentioned.

Then link the rest using clues

Clue	How it helps	Example
Full name, then short name	A person or thing is introduced in full, then referred to briefly	*Dr Maria Lopez…* comes before *Lopez…*
a then *the*	A new noun takes *a*; once mentioned, it takes *the*	*a new vaccine…* before *the vaccine…*
Pronouns and *this / these*	Always point back to something already said	*This discovery…* follows the discovery
Linking words	Show the relationship to the sentence before	*However* follows a contrasting idea
Time order	Dates, *first, later, eventually, today*	1854 before 1880 before today
General to specific	A broad claim usually comes before its evidence or example	Claim, then study, then result

Repeated words and phrases are also strong links: a key word at the end of one sentence often reappears at the start of the next. Allow about 2 to 3 minutes for each item, and no more than 4.

Because you score for each correct neighbouring pair, look for pairs that clearly belong together, such as a sentence and the one that explains its *this*. Even if the whole order is not right, correct pairs still earn marks.

Multiple Choice (single and multiple answers)

Multiple answers: negative marking

1. **Read the question first** and decide what it asks for: the main idea, a detail, the writer's purpose, an inference or the writer's attitude.
2. **Read the text** with that question in mind.
3. **Check each option against the text.** Choose it only if you can point to the part of the text that supports it.

How wrong options are built

- **Word trap:** it repeats words from the text but changes the meaning. The right answer is usually a paraphrase.
- **Too extreme:** words like *always, never, all, only, completely* often make an option wrong, because academic texts tend to be cautious (*may, often, some, tends to*).
- **True but not stated:** it may be true in real life, but the text does not say it.
- **Too narrow or too broad:** for a main-idea question, an option that covers one detail, or far more than the text, is wrong.

MULTIPLE ANSWERS

Each wrong choice cancels a right one. Select only options you can clearly support, often just one or two. If time is very short, choose the single option you are most sure of and move on.

SECTION 7

Listening

Every recording plays once. Apart from Summarize Spoken Text (covered on page 16), the tasks share one clock, so answer, check quickly and move on.

Note-taking symbols and abbreviations

Fast notes are essential for Re-tell Lecture, Summarize Group Discussion and Summarize Spoken Text. Practise a personal system until it is automatic. Drop vowels from long words (*gvt*, *dvlpmt*) and write only content words.

↑	increase, rise, grow	↓	decrease, fall, decline
→	leads to, causes, results in	←	caused by, comes from
=	is, means, equals	≠	is not, different from
+	and, also, in addition	**vs**	compared with, against
b/c	because	**e.g.**	for example
w/, **w/o**	with, without	∴	therefore, so
imp	important	**govt**	government
env	environment	**pt**	patient, point
res	research, result	**?**	question, unclear
A, B, C	speakers in a discussion	**✓ / ×**	agrees, disagrees

Fill in the Blanks

Type the missing words as you listen

1. In the few seconds before the audio, skim the text to see where the blanks are.
2. Click into the first blank. As the speaker reaches it, type the word straight away; fix spelling later.
3. Move to the next blank with the mouse, keeping your eyes on the text so you do not lose your place.
4. After the audio, check spelling, plurals and tense against the grammar of the sentence. If you missed a word, write the most likely word; a blank scores nothing.

If you are a slow typist, write the first few letters of each word on your notepad during the audio, then type the full words afterwards.

Highlight Correct Summary

Choose the best of four

- Before the audio, skim the four options quickly to get the topic and spot how they differ, but do not try to read them in detail.
- Note the main idea and two or three supporting points while listening.
- Rule out summaries that add information, contradict a point, or cover only one detail. The correct summary covers the **whole** recording, including the ending.

Multiple Choice (single and multiple answers)

Multiple answers: negative marking

- Read the question and the options before the recording starts, so you know what to listen for.
- Listen to the end; the speaker may change direction or add the key point last.
- As in Reading, the right answer is usually paraphrased, and an option that simply repeats words you heard is often a trap.
- Be wary of options with extreme words such as *always, never, only, all*; speakers tend to be more cautious.
- Rule out clearly wrong options first, then compare those left with your notes.
- For multiple answers, choose only what you clearly heard.

Select Missing Word

The ending is replaced by a beep

- Read the topic in the instructions and skim the options before the audio.
- Follow the direction of the argument. The missing words complete the speaker's logic, often signalled by words like *so*, *but*, *which means* or *as a result* just before the beep.
- Rule out options that are on topic but contradict what was said. Always choose an answer; there is no penalty.

Highlight Incorrect Words

Wrong clicks lose marks

1. Skim the text before the audio begins.
2. Follow the text with your mouse pointer, word by word, at the speaker's speed. Do not read ahead.
3. The moment a word differs from what you hear, click it and keep moving. The changed word often looks or sounds similar, or has a related meaning.
4. Only click words you are sure of. If you click by mistake, click again to remove the highlight.

Write from Dictation

Sentence 3–5 s · type it exactly

This task contributes to both Listening and Writing, and every correct word earns a mark. It comes at the end of the test, so **save time for it**: candidates who run out of time in Listening often lose these easy marks.

1. Keep your eyes open and stay focused; you hear the sentence only once. Listen for meaning and hold it in your head, as in Repeat Sentence.
2. Type immediately. If you prefer, jot the first letter of each word on your notepad as you listen, then expand them.
3. Check spelling, plurals, verb endings and small words such as *a, the, of, to*. Make sure the sentence is grammatical.
4. If you missed a word, write the word that best fits the grammar. A sensible guess may be right.

SECTION 8

Language toolkit

Describing trends and figures

Meaning	Verbs	Nouns and phrases
Going up	rise, increase, grow, climb, go up; sharply: soar, surge, jump	a rise, an increase, growth, an upward trend
Going down	fall, drop, decrease, decline, go down; sharply: plunge, plummet	a fall, a drop, a decline, a downward trend
No change	remain stable, stay steady, level off, stay the same	a period of stability, a plateau
Up and down	fluctuate, vary	fluctuations, a mixed pattern
Top and bottom	peak, reach a high of, hit a low of, bottom out	the peak, the highest point, the lowest level
Money and business	earn, spend, invest, profit, make a loss	revenue, profit, loss, margin, growth, share of the market

HOW FAST OR HOW MUCH

Large: sharply, dramatically, significantly, steeply
Moderate: steadily, considerably, noticeably
Small: slightly, gradually, marginally, a little

COMPARING

A is higher than B. · A is twice as high as B. · A accounts for the largest share. · A is followed by B. · In contrast, … · Similarly, …

POSITION WORDS FOR MAPS, PLANS AND PICTURES

at the top, at the bottom, on the left-hand side, on the right-hand side, in the centre, in the foreground, in the background, next to, opposite, between, above, below, in the north-east corner

Reporting verbs for lectures and discussions

Use a range instead of repeating *said*: *explained, described, argued, claimed, suggested, pointed out, noted, emphasised, mentioned, proposed, disagreed, agreed, concluded, recommended, warned.*

Linking words

Adding	and, also, in addition, furthermore, moreover, as well as
Contrast	but, however, although, whereas, while, on the other hand, despite, in contrast
Cause	because, since, as, due to, owing to
Result	so, therefore, as a result, consequently, which means that, leading to
Example	for example, for instance, such as, including, in particular
Sequence	first, then, next, after that, finally, eventually
Concluding	overall, in conclusion, to sum up, in short

Academic collocations worth learning

Fill in the Blanks tasks reward knowing which words go together. Learn these in phrases, not as single words.

With nouns	With prepositions	Adjective and noun
carry out research	rely on	significant number
conduct a study	depend on	widespread use
play a role	focus on	key factor
pose a threat	result in	rapid growth
have an impact on	contribute to	major cause
make a decision	respond to	common practice
draw a conclusion	known as	strong evidence
raise awareness	regarded as	long-term effect
meet a need	associated with	public health
reach an agreement	in harmony with	potential risk

Pronunciation habits to practise

- **Word endings.** Pronounce final *-s*, *-ed* and *-t* clearly. Dropping them can cost content and pronunciation marks.
- **Word stress.** Learn the stressed syllable of long academic words: *de**VEL**opment, eco**NOM**ic, a**NAL**ysis*, *pho**TOG**raphy*.
- **Linking.** Join words naturally inside a phrase (*a lot of_it*, *turn_off*), and pause between phrases, not between every word.
- **Numbers.** Practise saying years, percentages and large numbers aloud: *nineteen ninety-eight*, *two thousand and ten*, *forty-five percent*, *three point five million*.

Building your English between practice sessions

SHADOWING

Play a short clip of a clear speaker, such as a news broadcast, a lecture or a podcast. Pause after each sentence and repeat it, copying the rhythm and stress. Ten minutes a day improves Repeat Sentence, Read Aloud and fluency together.

READ, THEN SUMMARISE

Read one short academic or science article a day. Afterwards, write a one-sentence summary and say it aloud in 30 seconds. This trains Summarize Written Text and Re-tell Lecture at the same time.

RECORD YOURSELF

Record your Describe Image and Re-tell Lecture answers, then listen back. Count your pauses and fillers. Aim for fewer each week.

DAILY DICTATION

Type five to ten sentences from audio every day and check them word by word. Note words you misspell often and practise them.

SECTION 9

Four-week study plan

One to two hours a day for four weeks is enough for many nurses who already use English at work. Adjust the plan to your weakest skill, especially Speaking.

Week	Focus	Daily routine
Week 1	Learn the format and find your weak areas	Study sections 1 to 3. Try every task type once with real timings. Take a full practice test at the end of the week and note your lowest skill.
Week 2	Speaking technique	20 Repeat Sentence, 5 Read Aloud, 3 Describe Image and 2 Re-tell Lecture daily, recorded and played back. Add 2 Respond to a Situation and 1 Summarize Group Discussion. 10 Write from Dictation.
Week 3	Writing and Reading	1 essay and 1 Summarize Written Text, timed, each day. 10 Fill in the Blanks items and 2 Re-order Paragraphs. Keep 15 minutes of speaking practice daily.
Week 4	Listening and full tests	Two full practice tests in exam conditions, reviewing every mistake. On other days, practise your weakest three tasks. Stop heavy study the day before the test.

MINIMUM PRACTICE BEFORE TEST DAY

Complete at least 10 practice questions of every task type, record yourself in every Speaking task and listen back, and sit at least two full practice tests in exam conditions.

REVIEW EVERY MISTAKE

Practice only helps if you learn from it. For each wrong answer, write one line: what the right answer was and why you missed it (time, vocabulary, grammar, did not hear it, or guessed). Patterns appear within a week, and they tell you exactly what to practise next.

If your Speaking score is stuck

- **Check your microphone technique** first: position, volume and background noise during practice.
- **Listen to your recordings for pauses longer than one second.** Long pauses hurt fluency more than anything else.
- **Slow down slightly.** Many candidates speak too fast when nervous, which blurs word endings.
- **Focus on Repeat Sentence and Read Aloud** for a week. There are many items, and they show steady improvement with daily practice.
- **Simplify your Describe Image and Re-tell Lecture answers.** Fewer points delivered smoothly beat many points delivered with hesitation.

SECTION 10

Final checklists

DESCRIBE IMAGE

- ☐ I opened with the image type and topic
- ☐ I named the highest and lowest values
- ☐ I approximated figures instead of stopping
- ☐ I gave one comparison or trend
- ☐ I finished with a conclusion
- ☐ I did not stop for more than a second

RE-TELL LECTURE

- ☐ I opened with the topic
- ☐ I gave the main points, not small details
- ☐ I used only the speaker's ideas
- ☐ I followed the speaker's order
- ☐ I included the conclusion
- ☐ I spoke smoothly with few hesitations

RESPOND TO A SITUATION

- ☐ I spoke directly to the person
- ☐ My tone suited the relationship
- ☐ I stated the issue clearly
- ☐ I gave a reason or a solution
- ☐ I closed politely

SUMMARIZE GROUP DISCUSSION

- ☐ I stated the topic
- ☐ I gave each speaker's view and reason
- ☐ I used reporting verbs
- ☐ I included the outcome
- ☐ I spoke for most of the two minutes

SUMMARIZE WRITTEN TEXT

- ☐ One sentence, one full stop
- ☐ Between 5 and 75 words
- ☐ Main idea plus key supporting points
- ☐ No examples or minor details
- ☐ Grammar and spelling checked

WRITE ESSAY

- ☐ I answered every part of the question
- ☐ My position is clear in the introduction
- ☐ Each body paragraph has one main idea and an example
- ☐ My conclusion adds no new ideas
- ☐ Between 200 and 300 words
- ☐ Grammar and spelling checked

Test-day checklist

- ☐ Identification document matching my booking
- ☐ Arrive at least 30 minutes early
- ☐ Bathroom before the test starts
- ☐ Microphone positioned and volume checked
- ☐ Personal Introduction used to warm up
- ☐ Speak within two seconds; never pause for three
- ☐ Click Next only after "Completed"
- ☐ Check the clock in Reading and Listening
- ☐ Guess on single-answer tasks; be careful on multiple answers
- ☐ Leave time for Write from Dictation

NEXTGEN NURSES

Keep practising

Reading about strategy is the first step. Scores improve when you use these methods again and again under real time pressure, and review every mistake. Good luck from the NextGen Nurses team.

Practise every task with real timings

The **NextGen Nurses PTE Academic Practice App** has full practice tests in an exam-style screen, with recording for speaking tasks, timers, instant marking for Reading and most Listening items, sample answers, and estimated scores shown next to the NMBA targets.

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